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WHITE PAPER

The AI Accountability Workbook

A working kit for leaders who want AI doing real work, without losing track of who answers for it.

You can delegate the work. You cannot delegate the accountability.

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Companion to the talk “Using AI Is Easy. Governing It Is Hard.”

START HERE

How to use this workbook

Most teams already know how to use AI. Far fewer can say what it is allowed to see, say and decide, or whose name is on the result. This workbook helps you find where your gaps are and start closing them, in about an hour.

15 min	Run the Monday Morning Audit on one AI use. Just one.
20 min	Fill in the access inventory and the decision-rights matrix for your team.
10 min	Adopt the evidence standard, and send the vendor questions to whoever owns your AI contracts.
5 min	Ask your leadership team the three questions in section 8. Then decide who else needs this.

Where this comes from

Everything here comes from systems I run myself: an AI diagnostic for executive teams, a multi-agent marketing department, and an executive office that reads my mail and calendar. Each one taught me something by getting something wrong. The examples are real, with client details removed.

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SECTION 1

The Monday Morning Audit

Pick one AI use on your team: a tool, an agent, a vendor feature. Write it here, then answer five questions honestly.

The AI use I'm auditing	

1 ACCESS What can it access?

WHY IT MATTERS	Whatever it can read, it can leak, misuse or misquote. Most teams have never written the list down.
GOOD ANSWER	A written list of the data, accounts and systems it can read or change, and read-only wherever that is enough.
WARNING SIGN	"Whatever the vendor set up."
YOUR ANSWER	

2 CLAIM What is it allowed to claim, and on what evidence?

WHY IT MATTERS	AI writes fluently whether it is right or wrong. Fluent is not the same as right.
GOOD ANSWER	It says where each fact came from, and anything it cannot source is labeled unknown, not filled in.
WARNING SIGN	Numbers and statements nobody can trace.
YOUR ANSWER	

3 DECIDE What does it decide alone?

WHY IT MATTERS	Every decision it makes without a person is a decision you made in advance. Know which ones.
GOOD ANSWER	A short list of decisions it makes without a person, every one of them reversible.
WARNING SIGN	Nobody on the team can list them.
YOUR ANSWER	

4 APPROVE Who approves its work?

WHY IT MATTERS	Approval only works if the approver can see what matters, at the moment of approval.
GOOD ANSWER	A named person reviews the full output before it reaches a customer or the public, with risks made visible.
WARNING SIGN	Approval happens on a summary, or “the tool handles that.”
YOUR ANSWER	

5 OWN Whose name is on the outcome?

WHY IT MATTERS	When it goes wrong, the customer does not care which agent did it. They see a name.
GOOD ANSWER	One name.
WARNING SIGN	A committee, a vendor, or silence.
YOUR ANSWER	

> **If question 5 does not have one name, that is your governance gap.** You found it before it found you.

Fluent is not the same as right.

SECTION 2

Access inventory

List every AI tool or agent your team uses. If you cannot fill in a row, that is the finding.

Tool or agent	What it can read	What it can change	Who granted it	Read-only?	Last reviewed

A rule worth stealing: start read-only, and make it earn more. In my own executive office, every mailbox stays read-only until the drafts it writes clear a bar I set in advance: 8 of 10 sent as written or lightly edited, and no wrong fact sent.

SECTION 3

Decision-rights matrix

Every AI decision belongs in one of four bands. Decide which band before the AI does the work, not after.

Band	Who decides	Typical decisions	How it is checked
ROUTINE	The AI decides.	Wording, layout, formatting, small fixes that restore intended behavior.	Automated checks.
DELEGATED	The AI decides, with a second check.	Reversible choices inside an approved scope, where a mistake can be undone.	An independent reviewer agrees, and there is a tested way to undo it.
GOVERNANCE	A reviewer rules; you accept or push back.	Standards, evaluation criteria, brand and accuracy rules, anything with unclear scope.	Independent review.
EXECUTIVE	You decide. Every time.	Spending, new access or permissions, publishing, customer or stored data, strategy.	Nothing substitutes for you.

This matrix is a framework, not a finished policy. In my own systems, the Executive, Governance and Routine bands are how I work today; the Delegated band is still a proposal, not switched on. A reviewer from a different model or vendor reduces shared blind spots. It does not eliminate them. Two AIs can be wrong together.

Your team's matrix

Decision the AI touches	Band	Who decides	How it is checked

SECTION 4

The evidence standard

Five rules any team can adopt tomorrow. Put them in the instructions for every AI tool that writes anything a customer, executive or board will read.

1. **Every number names its source. Unknown is not zero.**
   If a figure cannot be traced, it is labeled unknown, never estimated into a sentence.
2. **Separate what happened from what is planned.**
   Label every claim as observed, implemented, proposed or experimental. Most AI overclaiming is a proposal described as a fact.
3. **One source counts once.**
   Five claims pulled from the same page are one piece of evidence, not five.
4. **A vendor's or competitor's own content is never independent.**
   Use it, label it, and never let it stand in for a third party.
5. **No "because" without proof.**
   When AI writes that one thing caused another, find the line in the analysis that supports it. If there is none, the sentence goes.

What rule 5 caught

THE REPORT SAID

"Buyers and AI assistants shortlisting you are working from credentials any competitor can restate, which leaves price doing the deciding."

THE ANALYSIS SAID

"We cannot say the positioning gap produced those losses, and we will not."

In an early run of my diagnostic, the report written from a careful analysis stated a cause the analysis had refused to make. No automated reviewer caught it, because the reviewers only checked the analysis, never the final report. A line-by-line check against the evidence did, before the client saw it. Now a check flags cause-and-effect wording the analysis does not support, and I read every report before it goes out.

SECTION 5

Case study: the placeholder I approved

A real incident from my own marketing department, written the way I want every team to write theirs.

What happened	On November 3, 2026, my marketing department's Writer agent put a drafting placeholder, "[Ryan: your moment]," back into a post, a day after I had said no personal moment was needed. It was the Writer's default at the time.
What the controls did	Both reviewer agents flagged it. One said it had to be filled before the post could go; the other said it was correct and I still needed to supply a moment. They disagreed, and neither could block. I then approved the post. The full text was on my screen, as plain text, with no highlight and no warning.
What the audience saw	On November 4 at 9:16 AM the post went out on X exactly as approved, with the placeholder as its first line. Thirteen people saw it before I fixed the live post by hand.
The prevention	Thirty-four minutes after it went out, the rule changed: placeholders are highlighted wherever a post's text appears, refused at approval, and held before sending, with a test for each path. The incident was logged as a production defect.
The lesson	Three controls each fell a little short, and no single check owned the problem. Approval is not governance if the approver cannot see what matters.

Write your own incident record

What happened, and what the audience saw	
What each control did	
The correction	
The prevention, and the test that proves it	
The lesson, in one sentence	

SECTION 6

Ten questions for any AI vendor

Ask these before you sign, and again at renewal. Vague answers are answers.

01 What data will your AI read, and can we limit it to read-only?

02 Where does our data go, and is it used to train your models?

03 Which models power the product, and will you tell us when that changes?

04 What can it do without a person approving it?

05 Can our approver see the full output before it reaches a customer, not a summary?

06 How does it show where a fact or number came from?

07 When it is unsure, does it say so, or does it fill the gap?

08 What usage or spending limits exist, and who can change them?

09 What is logged, for how long, and can we export it?

10 When it gets something wrong, how do we find out, and who at your company owns that?

There is no best model. There is a right model for the job.

And choosing it is itself a governance decision, especially when a vendor makes that choice for you.

SECTION 7

Your starter brief

The fastest way to build judgment about AI is a low-stakes project on something you know cold. I learned on a chicken incubator. Write a brief before the first prompt.

The goal, in one sentence	
What success looks like	
What I will supply, and what the AI must never assume	
Rules of engagement	
One decision boundary	

My first decision boundary, from the incubator brief: "I don't open the lid unless we both concur that it's the right action."

Three checkpoint prompts to include

- "Ask me any question that will help you accomplish the goal or provide more information."
- "Point out my blind spots."
- "Show me where I might be biased in my assessment of the solution to this problem."

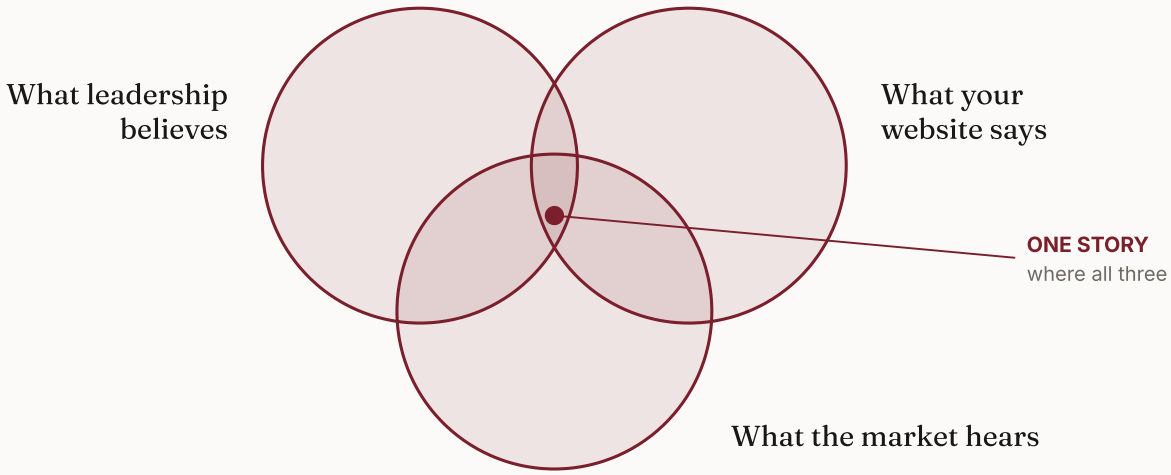
From my MarTech column, "Build your AI skills with a useful home project." Fair warning: the bias prompt works almost too well. I had to scale mine back when it started seeing bias in everything I did.

SECTION 8

Before you govern the AI, check the story it is amplifying

AI scales whichever version of your story it was fed. If your leadership team tells five different versions of why customers should choose you, AI will publish all five, faster and more confidently than any person could.

That disconnect, between what leadership believes, what your public material says and what the market hears, is what I call the Clarity Gap. It is a governance problem one level up from the AI.



The Clarity Gap is everything outside the overlap.

Three questions for your leadership team this week

1. Ask each leader separately: in one sentence, why does a customer choose us over the alternative?
2. When we lose a deal, who do we lose it to, and why, besides price?
3. Does our website say what our leaders just said?

> **If the answers do not match, you have found the gap.**

THE CLARITY GAP DIAGNOSTIC

Is your growth problem a clarity problem wearing a growth costume?

Your leadership team believes one story. Your website tells another. The market hears a third. Now AI is publishing all three, at scale. The Clarity Gap Diagnostic finds where those stories split.

- **About 15 minutes.** You answer a short set of questions about your company, your buyers, and how you win and lose.
- **Measured, not summarized.** Your answers are compared with your own public material and with what the market says about you, using a defined methodology.
- **A written read.** What is already working, where the stories split, and the one gap worth fixing first.
- **The AI finds the pattern. I check it before you see it.** Every report is read by me before it reaches you.

ryanphelan.com/
clarity-gap.html

For founders, CEOs and executive-team members. It's free, and in beta.

Not your call to make? Send this to your CEO, CMO or head of marketing. The page at **ryanphelan.com/ai-audit** has a one-click email you can forward.

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About Ryan Phelan

Ryan Phelan has spent nearly three decades in email, lifecycle and go-to-market marketing, starting in the dot-com era. He co-founded Affiliate Summit, served as CEO of RPE Origin, and has done earlier work inside Fortune 200 brands. He is the 2023 ANA Thought Leader of the Year, has written more than 100 columns for MarTech since 2017, and is a former Chair of the Email Experience Council.

Today he works with executive teams as a fractional CMO and go-to-market advisor, from strategy through the build. He also builds the AI systems he writes about, mistakes included. Operator first, consultant second.

Want to talk it through? **ryanphelan.com/chat**